illusions that that would do anything to improve its earning power.

Besides which, science fiction was going like a house afire, and I was deeply involved with The Caves of Steel.

Nevertheless, Schuman was talking not of textbooks, not of books for the general public even, but of books for teen-agers. That was a new wrinkle. I agreed to give it serious thought, but I kept my enthusiasm low. I was not in the market for more fiascos—yet I thought about it.

I was more impressed with something else that happened at about this time. On April 22, 1953, as a gesture of friendliness, I took a young woman whom I had met at the school to lunch at Howard Johnson's. She brought a girlfriend along and, as is common for me, I flirted outrageously.

Generally, women do not take me seriously in this respect, and I tended to rely on that. The girlfriend, however, whom I was meeting now for the first time, returned innuendo for innuendo in the coolest possible manner and left me uncertain as to what to do.

Eventually lunch was over, and since I had agreed, to begin with, to drive the young woman I knew to her next appointment, I did so. Her friend accompanied us and then asked if I would drive her home to her place in Cambridge, and it would have been ungallant of me to refuse. When I got there, she invited me up to her apartment, and again it would have been ungallant of me to refuse.

What it amounts to is that she then seduced me.

Don't get me wrong. She didn't use force, or even much in the way of persuasion. Nor did I object or scream or fight.

However, I was scared, and even though I was alone with a woman in her own apartment, a woman who was plainly intent on sex, there wasn't a chance in the world that I would have made the first move. But I didn't have to. She did and I just followed along, with my teeth more or less chattering, and not out of passion.

I was just about a third of a century old and it was the first time I had ever indulged in illicit sex, either premarital or extramarital.

It left me riddled with guilt and yet, in an odd way, triumphant. I had never really felt myself to be "good in bed." I had known for years that I was not